What would Indian urban life be like without posters of political leaders staring at pedestrians? More importantly, ever wondered what happens to these banners made of vinyl sheets once they have outlived their purpose of inflating "the egos of neighbourhood apparatchiks during functions and festivals"? Curated by Ranjit Hoskote, Ritesh Uttamchandani's debut show *A Lease of Life* (on view at the Cymroza Art Gallery, Mumbai, until February 28) tracks these posters down to the most unexpected settings where they are repurposed rather imaginatively—as body covers for auto-rickshaws, awnings for roadside stalls and mats for vegetable vendors.

Hoskote's favourite image is that of a boy sitting at a roadside stall with a political poster forming part of the display surface. "For a brief moment," Hoskote says, "the loud rhetoric of leadership becomes incidental, while the hopes and dreams of the child fill us with anticipation of a better, more just and inclusive future." Hopes and dreams aside, many serve as a sly ode to Mumbaikars' legendary survival instinct, or *jugaad*. One amusing photograph features a pair of shorts drying over Rahul Gandhi's head, another shows a local politician's smiling visage emerging from under a mound of *chappals*.

You might find beneath the black comedy a subtle commentary on rampant urbanisation, cultural bricolage, red tape, labour migration, public engagement with civic spaces, architecture and infrastructure. "To me, the seeming whimsicality of the manner in which these posters are recycled by their new users, their secondary and tertiary users, if you will, offers us a distinctive way of reading political reality—the passing and fall of power and influence in time, the transience of authority and the arrogance of rulers," says Hoskote.

RITESH UTTAMCHANDANI'S DEBUT SHOW REVEALS HOW POLITICAL POSTERS ARE REPURPOSED IMAGINATIVELY

On a visit to one of the places where these political posters are manufactured, Uttamchandani realised that they had templates, just like everything else in the so-called 'City of Dreams'. "In Mumbai, there's a consistent murder of original thought at several levels," he says. A former photojournalist, Uttamchandani is drawn to what he calls an "alternative way of seeing the world". He seems adept at making striking images out of things that often go unnoticed. The years spent in journalism taught him many things, including his work ethic and how to shoot on the go. "There came a time when I started getting fatigued by not just what I saw around me but by my own work. Newsrooms can be very welcoming towards conventional approaches but not so much towards tangential thoughts," says Uttamchandani, who quit his job at *Open* magazine in 2015. Three years later, he self-published a fable-esque photo-book titled *The Red Cat and Other Stories*. Excerpts from it are seamlessly embedded into *A Lease of Life*, helping provide context to Uttamchandani's work, which seems to borrow equally from photographer Peter Bialobrzeski's urban realism and Hrishikesh Mukherjee's cinema.

Hoskote, who has followed the photographer's work for close to a decade, first saw *The Red Cat...* on his laptop and instantly knew that "[Ritesh's] imagination was attuned to matters of literary and artistic form, apart from being engaged with documentarian preoccupations". Hoskote promises that *A Lease of Life* is the first in a cycle of exhibitions that he is curating for the Cymroza Art Gallery that will "address photographic practice and the complexities of the everyday". ■

–Shaikh Ayaz







"By integrating high-resolution images with virtual tours, video, audio, maps and viewing notes, curators can present compelling stories online"

SIMON REIN
Senior Program Manager, Google Arts & Culture

"Google Arts & Culture shared the project's vision of access and excellence. Their team guided and supported our curators and editors at every stage"

ADITI NAYAR
Director, Kerala Museum



guiding principle when selecting artworks for digitisation. Showcasing both highlights and hidden gems, the digitised collection helps tell the story of Indian artists and of artist collectives against the backdrop of the nation's historical and cultural atmosphere.

Interesting insights become evident when one visits the website (artsandculture.google.com/partner/kerala-museum). For starters, viewers can easily comprehend the legacies of modernists such as Subramanyan and Madhava Menon. They can also see the long relations and patterns of influence that connect the Kerala, Shantiniketan and Baroda schools of art. "Google Arts & Culture shared the project's vision of access and excellence. Their team guided and supported our curators and editors at every stage of the project," says Nayar. And Google, for its part, is committed to expanding its net by adding yet more collections online. "Since the start of Google Arts & Culture in 2011, more than 2,000 cultural institutions from 88 countries have shared their collections in thousands of immersive exhibitions," says Rein. ■

–Rahul Kumar